Pride and Prejudice: Character Quotations

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Written by: Sam Evans
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
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GCSE English Literature exam questions usually focus on a theme, a character or a relationship between two or more characters. Examiners reward responses that track the development of characters or themes through the text.

When revising, try to consider quotes in terms of their dramatic effects — how the words are spoken, what attitudes or relationships are presented and why these ideas have been shown to the audience.

We've included the best Pride and Prejudice quotes — with detailed analysis — to help you to revise and organised them by the following characters:

- **Elizabeth Bennet**
- **Fitzwilliam Darcy**
- **Jane Bennet**
- **Charles Bingley**

> Examiners don't want you to remember lots of long lines, but rather to consider how a character's dialogue represents a theme. The best answers consider what feelings or philosophies are behind the words, or what the character's words imply (Austen's characters never just say what they mean). Remember, the characters' communication style tells readers a lot about the society, and therefore illustrates many of Austen's ideas.
>
> Here, we've included a "key word or phrase" from every one of our longer quotations to help you keep your focus on the most important parts of each quotation.

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Elizabeth Bennet

Elizabeth Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "alter" and "new"	**What the quotation means:** Elizabeth says that studying someone's character is pointless, as they change so much	**Theme:** Social class

- Challenging Darcy's complaints about his "unvarying" social life, Elizabeth offers a positive perspective:
  - Austen shows how Elizabeth's outlook contrasts with Darcy's pessimism
- Elizabeth emphatically offers his opinion that people should not be harshly judged:
  - The words "alter" and "new" illustrates her **magnanimous** attitude
  - Her tolerance for others conveys Austen's challenge to pride and prejudice, and foreshadows Elizabeth's later attitudes

> **"There are few people whom I really love, and still fewer of whom I think well. The more I see of the world, the more am I dissatisfied with it"** - Elizabeth Bennet, Chapter 24

Elizabeth Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "few" and "more"	**What the quotation means:** Elizabeth tells Jane that her world is beyond her understanding, and that she finds it challenging to like or trust people because they are inconstant	**Theme:** Love and marriage

- Elizabeth tells Jane that she believes Charlotte's marriage is impossible to explain
- Elizabeth's **rhetoric** presents her as passionate:
  - **Anaphora** emphasises her belief that the world is confusing
  - Austen uses **juxtaposition** to contrast the words "few" and "more"
  - This highlights Elizabeth's tendency to be extreme and contrary

> **"What are men to rocks and mountains?"** - Elizabeth Bennet, Chapter 27

Elizabeth Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "men" and "mountains"	**What the quotation means:** Elizabeth is ecstatic to be travelling to the Lake District, and tells her aunt that she is very pleased to be going to see rocks and mountains instead of the men in Derbyshire	**Theme:** Gender roles

• Elizabeth's uneasy attitude to romance is clear when she tells her aunt that nature is about "life and vigour":
  ○ She contrasts this with an emotive description of men ("disappointment and spleen")
  ○ Her attitude to love and marriage contradicts the attitudes of other female characters
• The alliterative "men" and "mountains" draws attention to the strong and constant nature of mountains:
• This highlights the conflict between humans and nature, a Romantic philosophy			

> **"There is a stubbornness about me that never can bear to be frightened at the will of others. My courage always rises with every attempt to intimidate me"** - Elizabeth Bennet, Chapter 31

Elizabeth Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "courage" and "stubbornness"	**What the quotation means:** Elizabeth replies to Mr Darcy's request that she play piano, saying she is aware of his attempts to humiliate her	**Theme:** Social class

Help me understand

- Austen highlights Elizabeth's boldness with extreme statements:
  - She says she will "never" be "frightened" by others, even Mr Darcy
  - Through Elizabeth, Austen presents a challenge to snobbery

Fitzwilliam Darcy

> **"I have been meditating on the very great pleasure which a pair of fine eyes in the face of a pretty woman can bestow"** - Fitzwilliam Darcy, Chapter 6

Fitzwilliam Darcy	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "pleasure" and "pretty"	**What the quotation means:** When Darcy is accused of being bored, he rejects this, saying that he takes "pleasure" in watching Elizabeth, who is "pretty"	**Theme:** Gender roles

- Darcy's attraction to Elizabeth is met with shock as he often takes pleasure in challenging Elizabeth:
  - Austen **foreshadows** their relationship by highlighting their similar natures
- Darcy's remarks about Elizabeth imply the value placed in a woman's appearance:
  - This illustrates attitudes to gender roles in Georgian England

> **"There is, I believe, in every disposition a tendency to some particular evil, a natural defect, which not even the best education can overcome"** - Fitzwilliam Darcy, Chapter 11

	Key word or phrase to memorise:	**What the quotation means:** Darcy suggests that	**Theme:** Social class

		which he believes applies to all people, regardless of social class or education	

- Darcy's pessimism and resentment applies equally to everyone, and thus, Austen presents him as fair:
  - His belief, that it is natural to be flawed, presents him as equally distrustful of all people
- He implies that there is no such thing as a superior human:
  - Through Darcy, Austen raises questions about whether social standing equates to goodness

> **"It was unpardonable. I cannot think of it without abhorrence"** - Fitzwilliam Darcy, Chapter 58

Fitzwilliam Darcy	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "unpardonable"	**What the quotation means:** When Darcy expresses his love to Elizabeth, he is ashamed of his prior snobbery, describing it as hateful ("abhorrent") and unworthy of forgiveness	**Theme:** Love and marriage

- Austen presents Darcy as a worthy match for Elizabeth as he is willing to change:
  - He appears to feel genuine love for her and desires an equal relationship
- This romantic scene portrays Darcy as humble and apologetic, as well as fair:
  - Earlier in the novel, Darcy suggests that he is "too little yielding" of "vices"
  - Here, he applies this judgement to his own failings, illustrating integrity

Jane Bennet

> **'sensible, good humoured, lively; and I never saw such happy manners! — so much ease, with such perfect good breeding!'"** - Jane Bennet, Chapter 4

Jane Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "ought" and "perfect"	**What the quotation means:** When Jane describes what a perfect man should be, she mentions typically good qualities, but adds that he should come from a good family	**Theme:** Gender roles

• Jane conveys Austen's ideas about the significance of class in Georgian England:
  ○ She plainly states that the "perfect" man should be well-bred
  ○ The adjective "perfect" is suggestive of the high standards required for marriage (a sought after status at the time)
• Jane's remarks highlight the strict code of conduct that was required by a "young man":
  ○ For example, she mentions "happy manners", which refers to the importance of politeness
• The **modal verb** "ought" suggests obligation and the importance of duty			

> **"My confidence was as natural as your suspicion"** - Jane Bennet, Chapter 26

Jane Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "confidence" and "suspicion"	**What the quotation means:** Jane writes that, although Elizabeth was right about Caroline's insincerity, she still thinks that her decision to trust Caroline is as good as Elizabeth's choice to suspect her	**Theme:** Social class

distrustful nature

- Jane's kind and tolerant nature is portrayed as she gently admonishes Elizabeth:
  - The **oxymoronic** "confidence" and "suspicion" highlights the difference between Jane and Elizabeth

> **"Oh, Lizzy! do any thing rather than marry without affection"** - Jane Bennet, Chapter 59

Jane Bennet	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "do anything" and "affection"	**What the quotation means:** Jane tells Elizabeth that she should be sure about her marriage to Darcy, and that she should avoid marrying him if she dislikes him	**Theme:** Love and marriage

- While Jane's sensible nature often contrasts with Elizabeth's passion, here she conveys extreme emotions:
  - The **imperative** phrase "do anything" illustrates her concern that Elizabeth is marrying Darcy even though she dislikes him
- Jane's words portray the challenges in a society that defines marriage as a means to survival, or improved social mobility:
  - Austen portrays Jane's uneasiness about her sister's marriage
  - Nevertheless, "affection" (meaning fondness or liking) highlights Jane's stance that marriage is not about passion

Charles Bingley

> **"And I wish my collection were larger for your benefit and my own credit; but I am an idle fellow"** - Charles Bingley, Chapter 8

Charles Bingley	"for your benefit" and "idle fellow"	apologises to Elizabeth for his limited collection of books, accepts this lets him down in her eyes, and explains it is because he is lazy	

- Austen juxtaposes Bingley's humility with Darcy's arrogance:
  - Bingley's deference to Elizabeth contrasts with Darcy's snobbery
- Here, Bingley states that a large library would "credit" him:
  - This contrasts with Darcy's library which is the "work of many generations"
  - This conveys Bingley's insecurities about his social standing

> **"At least, therefore, I did not assume the character of needless precipitance merely to shew off before the ladies"** - Charles Bingley, Chapter 10

Charles Bingley	**Key word or phrase to memorise:** "merely" and "shew off"	**What the quotation means:** Bingley rejects Darcy's challenge to his humility and integrity, insisting that he did not assume the identity of a quick writer, or pretend to be something he was not, just to impress the female company	**Theme:** Love and marriage

- Darcy's suggestion that he assumed an identity in order to flirt is strongly rejected
- Austen illustrates Bingley's distaste for falseness with the word "merely":
  - He is adamant that his intention was not simply to win over the "ladies"
- Austen illustrates conflicts resulting from her society's preoccupation with marriage

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